

Reflections on Paul's Letter to the Romans:

The question of Justification before God:

One of the main themes in the letter is the tension between **faith** and **good works** in relation to the question of justification in the eyes of God, thereby achieving salvation. In other words, Paul intends to answer the question, 'Who gets saved?' in an eschatological sense. Paul begins tackling the question by looking at what would constitute grounds for justification in front of God.

Paul refers in Romans 2:6 to God as being a fair judge who will "render to each one according to his works" *τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ*. Prima facie, one may take this to mean that *doing good works* is a sufficient condition for achieving salvation. Paul, however, does not think that's the case. To demonstrate this, he turns to the question, 'What makes a good deed good'. For, salvation or justification is not 'due' to one who does works, but, specifically, to the one who does **good works**. Thus, if it were the case that good works are a sufficient condition for salvation, then inquiring what makes good works good takes a structural and analytical priority; for, in determining this, one has a response to the question of who's worthy of salvation.

The first option is to argue that the Jewish population has an advantage since they are explicitly favoured by God, as in Deuteronomy 7:6. Secondly, they have codified the will of God into the Law of Moses, thereby acting in conformity with the Law – they are the people of the Book. Thus, Paul explores this option in Romans 2:12-16, where he introduces a distinction between the people under the law and not under the law. If it were the case that only people of the Book were candidates for salvation, and, by extension, Gentiles were in principle doomed to

live without the possibility of salvation, then it would follow that it should be impossible for Gentiles to perform any action warranting salvation. Paul refutes this idea when he conceives of the possibility of Gentiles **doing what the law requires** without possessing the law ('possessing' in the sense that they are brought up with reference to the Law and under the Law). This possibility is admitted by Paul, who appeals to simple empirical perception of examples where the Gentiles **do what the law requires** *because* the law is written in the heart. The law is inscribed in the Gentile's heart (ἐν ταῖς καρδίαις), who also possess **conscience** (τῆς συνειδήσεως). Thus, if the Gentiles have a conscience that dictates or observes their actions whose essence is in line with the Law, and if the Law's inscription is not on Tablets, but on their hearts, then it follows that the difference between the Jew and the Gentile is not one of quality – both are of the same nature. Instead, the difference between Jews and Gentiles is one of epistemic access to the content of sin, i.e., the former has better or more holistic access to **knowledge of** what is sinful and what is good. But this knowledge does not imply an exclusive capacity to do **that which the law dictates**. Knowledge **of** appears to be taken as propositional knowledge-that instead of the type that Paul considers the true mark of good works, namely a know-how type of knowledge that is habitual. Furthermore, in terms of salvation, Jews and Greeks are considered radically equal in front of God, "For God shows no partiality" (Romans 2:11). This necessary implication follows from the fact that Gentiles can perform what the law requires, and if what gets rewarded is performances of good actions, then it follows that Gentiles can be saved in the same way as people of the Book. Therefore, the first option Paul explores, namely that Jews have a priority pass to salvation because they have the Law, concludes that **both** Jews and Greeks, when it comes to salvation, are equal in front of God **and** that **knowing** the Law does not entail necessarily or exclusively **doing** what the Law requires of you. Thus, Paul explores a second option: **faith**, not the Law, makes good deeds good. Before outlining this option, let me clarify how Paul views the law, to which he attributes some positive functions.

Paul should not be read as calling for discarding the law. His intention is not to argue that Moses' commandments, for example, are of no value regarding morality or one's way of life. He takes the Law and its content to stand conceptually apart in that the law represents that which is **good in itself**—irrespective of whether it has been codified or not. Thus, the law symbolises the good, but it is not **the** good in itself. This understanding can be seen in Barth's suggestion that the Bible expresses the Word (witness to the Word) but is not the Word itself. This means that there is a conceptual and material separation between the thing itself and the means through which it is expressed or recorded. Paul reflects this understanding in his treatment of circumcision as inconsequential in assessing the value of the doer, in the sense of determining the quality of their actions. For that reason, he says, "For circumcision indeed is of value if you obey the law, but if you break the law, your circumcision becomes uncircumcision" (Romans 2: 25). The Law, nevertheless, serves a significant purpose: that is, the Law makes explicit that which is implicit in the moral reality of intersubjective interactions. In other words, the Law gives epistemic access to that which is good or prohibited, thereby making the content of the good or prohibition a commandment for the person who **knows** the law. Hence, the Law, according to Paul, serves an intellectual and didactic purpose in that it is an efficient and effective way whereby one can come in contact with God's will (See Aquinas for an elaboration of this point to a coherent view). The law and sin are mutually independent, in that sin does not come into being with the law. In other words, law and sin are conceptually independent **because** they are materially independent. As Paul suggests, "sin did indeed was in the world before the law was given", implying that some actions are inherently wrong independently of whether they are described as such by a legalistic edifice (Romans 5:13). Paul commits to an idea of morality where slavery or genocide, for example, are both wrong before their codification as such, and, from a natural law perspective, they are being codified as wrong **because** they are independently wrong. It is the moral quality of wrongness that makes genocide wrong and not the fact that it is being described as prohibited by human

legislation. Thus, the first positive function of the law is making explicit that which is implicitly or tacitly 'known', even if merely 'in practice'. Are there any other positive functions of the law?

Paul indirectly refers to yet another positive function of the law, which, however, proves to be irrelevant to the question of salvation or justification. In the quote above, Romans 5:13, the passage continues, "but sin is not counted where there is no law". One can read Paul as distinguishing between two separate questions by taking the law as capable of 'counting' sins. We established that, on the one hand, the Law is irrelevant to the question of salvation, since it only applies to Jews, and there is no difference between Jew or Greek in front of God (Romans 2:11). On the other hand, amongst humans, the idea of being able to 'count sins' implies that having the Law enables us to open up questions regarding responsibility, accountability, and fairness. For, in being able to count sins, one can mete out justice and cultivate an idea of responsibility and accountability in a people – in more general terms, one can concretely flesh out an idea of Being-guilty, both in individual and communal terms. Thus, whilst the law might be irrelevant regarding salvation, the prescription of the law is a necessary condition for an idea of justice between people, as well as of moral accountability and a sense of duty towards our fellow humans. Therefore, for Paul, the Law has a double positive function. First, it makes the content of morality explicit by codification, and second, it enables a population to tap into concepts necessary for intersubjective relations. Let me move back to the question of faith versus works.

We saw that Paul discards the possibility that the works of law grant one salvation. This is because the law might produce knowledge of the good but cannot guarantee its performance. But, one could question this conclusion on the following grounds: if the Law states what is good, and God rewards the good, then following the Law should be rewarded. The fact that the performance is not guaranteed is not a problem of the structure of salvation but of human weakness. Paul is aware of this challenge and turns to Abraham's story to demonstrate that the Law, despite its

utility, is inconsequential in the question of salvation or justification. According to Paul, Abraham's reward in Genesis 18-22 is the outcome of **faith** rather than following the law. The reason for this is not that Abraham is a lawbreaker; instead, at this point, no Law has been received in the form of commandments. For example, when Abraham demonstrates that he is prepared to sacrifice Isaac, he acts **out of faith** rather than **out of duty to the law**. In other words, Abraham acts **because he possesses faith**, and what God rewards is this faith, which is shown as unwavering despite the nature of God's request. Therefore, if the patriarch of Judaism stood justified before God not because of the Law but due to his faith, and if this justification was given to Abraham not as a fulfilment of a contractual obligation but freely after demonstration of faith, then it follows that one is justified in front of God through **faith** and that God freely gives such justification – if he so chooses. We can distinguish between subjective and objective realms, which helps make this point tangible. From a subjective point of view, the only thing within the agent's power is to possess and demonstrate his faith; whether this faith will be rewarded or not is extra-subjective, and thus outside of one's control. Paul suggests that if one completes one's part (the subjective realm), one should trust that God, being fair, **will** reward him. As Paul says, one should not understand **grace** in terms of being paid for work done, as is the case for one's wages, which "are not counted as a gift but as [his] due" (Romans 4:4). Thus, from a human perspective, one can only follow the example of Abraham, who "ἐπίστευσεν τῷ Θεῷ"; at this point, that's all one can do. Abraham was 'given' justification by someone else, God, and this is expressed clearly in the passive voice sentence in Romans 4:3.

There are two related questions at this point. If faith is sufficient, is there a way to determine whether one has faith or not? Second, has Paul answered the original question, "What makes good works good"? Regarding the first question, one can infer that Paul would respond affirmatively, given that Abraham's possession of faith is not taken for granted. Abraham's faith is put to the test by God when he is asked to sacrifice Isaac. Thus, the content of faith is not an

internal property of the mind where one's declaration of faith suffices to establish possession of faith. Rather, faith is possessed **in action**; in other words, faith is a disposition to act in a certain way that becomes evident **in action**. Hence, according to Paul, the 'true' Christian, or the one who shall receive salvation, is not the one who merely confesses their faith, but, instead, the one who professes their faith and acts on it. Therefore, Luther's reading of what is required to be good when he says that "faith makes good, and not works alone" aligns with the Pauline understanding of faith.

For the second question, Paul has, indeed, responded: good works are good if, and only if, the doer acts out of faith. Faith here means performing that which is the content of the law, regardless of whether one is under the law. Thus, no amount of good deeds can count as good if they are **motivated** by faith, which can be understood as the state in which one is ready and willing to **live** according to God's commandment, as well as willing to demonstrate one's faith when presented with a test of faith. Given that Paul views the relationship between man and God in non-reciprocal terms, he commits to the conclusion that from a human, subjective point of view, commitment to our faith and trust in God is the desired state to be achieved, without this implying an expectation with regards to the question of salvation – no person, or amount of action justifies the debtor/creditor interpretation of salvation. This is because grace cannot be owed to anyone since it's God's prerogative who shall receive it or not. Had it been otherwise, this would mean that anyone can earn grace. For example, imagine someone who acts in line with the law but only to receive a reward. According to Paul, this person cannot be entitled to justification before God since, to a certain extent, his motivation is not in line with God – he is doing good without himself being good. However, within the legalistic understanding of salvation, solely based on works, this imaginary person would be **entitled** to salvation – which is a conclusion that Paul feels uncomfortable with.

The content of Faith:

What is **Faith** according to Paul, and how does one distinguish between the faithful and the unfaithful? We already have established that what makes one faithful differs from how one demonstrates one's faith. That is, circumcision, which serves as an indicator of faith, differs from following the law in practice, which is closer to faith itself. Hence, as I have suggested, Paul considers the Gentiles capable of doing good irrespective of whether they are circumcised or not.

One may be able to respond to the question of faith by starting negatively, i.e., by analysing what faith is not, according to Paul. First, faith is not a mental state conditioned to the reception of a reward. That is, if one believes/has faith on the condition that (and as long as) one shall receive a reward **because** of their faith, then one cannot be classified as faithful in Paul's sense. This understanding can be couched in rational-utilitarian terms: S1 believes in X **iff** S1 derives a direct or indirect benefit from **believing** X. If we transpose the idea of God into this scheme, we can infer that S1 believe in God **iff** one directly or indirectly benefits **from** believing and **because** of believing. Thus, the idea of conditional faith implies a rational calculation, which, for Paul, cannot be part of the interpretation of faith, for faith is an original disposition from which one starts and **not** the outcome of rational deliberation to which one reasons.

Paul indirectly alludes to the following distinction between faith and rationality through his use of the story of Abraham, who demonstrates the meaning of possessing faith versus possessing faith **because** of rewards. Abraham's willingness to sacrifice Isaac indicates that his psychological or ontological makeup begins from and with faith, which is radically different from faith acquired via rational deliberation. The rationally acquired faith proceeds as follows: Given that I want/desire to achieve/acquire X, what is the most efficient/appropriate way to get that which I desire? If we couple this question with the assertion, 'There exists an all-powerful God',

then, rationally speaking, an individual should commit to faith. Faith is that through which one may attain that which one desires. This type begins from a rational perspective and finds faith along the way as a means. The basic ontological/psychological makeup of this person is the rational agent.

For Paul, the rational agent should not be conflated with the faithful. Abraham does not begin with rational consideration and finds himself in faith as a means to attain the promised goods. Abraham is **in faith**. Does this mean that Abraham must not expect a reward? Or, if he so receives it, should he not have desired/wanted the reward? Not necessarily. From a subjective point of view, the only important element in distinguishing the man of faith from the rest is that he acts as a 'knight of faith' (Kierkegaard), i.e., acting from and being in faith, without anything further. Outside this subjective realm lies the question of 'reward' or 'expectation', and regarding this extra-subjective element, the 'knight of faith' can have trust but not an expectation of the reward. The problem with admitting the concept of expectation in the structure of salvation is that expectation can receive classification as reasonable or not reasonable. One can reasonably expect X **based on** or **because of** having performed Y. One can understand this structure by analysing the institution of 'promising'. S1 has a reasonable expectation of receiving goods from S2 based on S2's promise of giving them the goods, which was done based on/because of S1's performance. Thus, S1 has rational grounds for expecting X. In that manner, if S1 does not receive the goods, despite his performance, then S1 has a reasonable claim against S2.

Beginning from a position of faith/with faith cannot be interpreted in the above manner. The knight of faith **does this** because of his faith, because they **are** in faith, and not because they expect something in return. This is why whether Abraham receives or not is impertinent to **his** faith. As well as, from the fact that Abraham received his reward, it does not follow that he had faith **because** of the expected reward, and this is precisely the point of salvation through faith

alone. The very idea of being a candidate for receiving salvation requires that one has faith without, at the same time, having a claim to salvation **because** of their deeds – even if these deeds are the outcomes of faithful activity. Therefore, Paul construes faith in Romans (4-5) as irrational in that faith motivates but does not calculate.

What is the difference between acting out of faith and rational when following the law? Besides the structure of expectation, which is a rational deliberation process, does faith differ from rational agency in any other respect? Paul suggests a qualitative difference between being motivated by faith and reason. First, according to Paul, faith appears to be a sufficient motivating force compared to rational deliberation. In a sense, Abraham is motivated by his faith in that his faith, construed as obedience to or fear of God, is the cause of his behaviour. The content of faith seems to entail, but is not exhausted by, knowledge of the law and the practising of the law. Second, rationality cannot motivate by itself because the rational agent requires a set of desires onto which he applies a rational deliberation process, whereby that which he desires may be attained most efficiently. Thus, by beginning with a negative determination of what faith is not, we reach two characteristics that faith **is**: namely, a) faith is different from rational deliberation because one can act out of faith without or despite rational calculations, and b) faith is a sufficient motivating force for agents to perform actions whilst rationality is dependent on prior desires.

The last characteristic stemming from Abraham's story is that faith is related to (if not identical to) obedience. That is, to be faithful would simply mean to be obedient. The natural question arising, then, is how to construe 'obedience'. Obedience to what or to whom clarifies the meaning of faith. Paul is essentially unclear on this point. I want to suggest three possible interpretations that explicate the meaning of obedience.

1. One can focus on his remarks about the spirit of the Law versus the letter of the Law and infer that one is faithful if one is obedient to the Spirit of the Law. This interpretation could be substantiated by seeing that it aligns with the person of Christ. For example, in Mark (2:23-28), where Jesus 'breaks' the letter of the Law by working on the Sabbath and proclaims that the prohibitions of the Law (i.e., work during the Sabbath) were created **for** man and not vice-versa (i.e., the man was **not** created **for** Sabbath). Thus, Jesus clearly demonstrates that the Spirit of the Law and the Letter of the Law are conceptually different things that might or might not go hand in hand.
2. A second interpretation would be that obedience is owed to God, and from this 'original' obedience stems an indirect duty to obey the Law, as revealed to various prophets. This would mean that if the Law has been revealed, then one owes obedience to the Law because of their primary obedience to God since the revelation of the Law comes from the revelation of God. This interpretation would be in line with what Paul suggests in Romans 2-4 in that the "Jew has an advantage" insofar as he knows the Law, which, though insufficient by itself for salvation, commands secondary obedience due to its primary revelation.
3. Luther's interpretation of faith focuses on faith shown in 'vocation' and acceptance of one's 'calling'. The radical acceptance of one's position in Divine Ordinance entails the acceptance of one's horizon in existence. For example, the possibility of demonstrating faith as the son of the farmer is the conscientious and laborious performance of the tasks associated with one's vocation that result from one's factual position in a societal hierarchy. Thus, Luther interprets the calling of faith and the acceptance of this calling in terms of embracing one's 'vocation' that results from life. This interpretation has two limitations. First, there is an implied fatalism in Luther's account in that one's possibilities are determined by one's social position in the order of estates. It is unclear whether one **can** or **should** escape their 'fate', in the sense of aspiring for something 'more'. Heidegger

interprets this point in deterministic terms, suggesting that Christians must accept their ‘calling’ and not toil in order to achieve this-worldly things (e.g., a change in social status). Instead, the faithful Christian can **be** in faith irrespective of their position, and hence being in line with the requirement to receive grace. Secondly, Kierkegaard and Weber both observed that Luther’s conception of ‘calling’ as ‘vocation’ resulted in the creation of “petite bourgeois” who succeed within capitalist economies, consume in a fundamentally non-Christian way, and justify this consumption and way of life as excelling in their ‘vocation’. Moreover, excelling in their vocation, in this interpretation is a demonstration of their faith through accepting their calling, thereby resulting in a way of being that’s antithetical to anything Christian. Thus, the second limitation is that Luther’s framework might have been intended in a radically different way than it was received – however, the reception resulted in something clearly anti-Christian. Nevertheless, this interpretation has a strength over the Catholic and Orthodox understanding of ‘calling’. Namely, the latter interpretation suggests that ascetic life and the clergy are in a privileged position with respect to the laity, and hence ‘calling’ is taken to imply a division between those who deny worldly vocations and conform to the higher calling of asceticism and those who do not. Luther’s interpretation of calling as vocation eradicates this distinction and situates both the ascetic and non-ascetic on the same plane in the eyes of God.

The Question of Human Nature:

Paul refers to Adam as the first sinner but also as a representative of a “type of human” (ὅς ἐστιν τύπος του μέλλοντος) (Romans 5:12). This justifies two inferences. First, Paul appears to have a literal reading of Genesis, in that he ascribes to Adam the property of having actually been the ‘first sinner’; moreover, Adam represents a typology of humans that has become dominant, namely the one whose disposition is essentially sinful. The story of Adam expresses a moral

meaning in that he represents what must have been Paul's observation of everyday humans in his time.

What is sin? Paul outlines examples of sinful actions both in Romans and in Galatians. For example, there is no surprise when he offers in Galatians an outline of canonical sinful actions from a Christian perspective, "sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality, idolatry, [...]" (Galatians 5:19-20). Likewise, there is no surprise when he offers a conventional list of virtuous actions in Romans, "Love one another with brotherly affection. Outdo one another in showing honour [...]", again, from within a Christian perspective (Romans 12:9-21). However, one should ask what sin is and not what an example of sin would be. For, grasping the latter presupposes an understanding of the former. One understands idolatry as sinful if the definition of sin is grasped in advance. Such a grasp becomes evident when one is forced by means of concepts to classify an action of idolatry as sinful. Paul answers this question by focusing on agency, and by drawing on his phenomenology, he demonstrates how sin operates in humans. In Romans (7:13-24), Paul attests to the power of sin when he refers to sin as overtaking one's power to **do the good** even if one **wills** to do the good. Sin is associated in both Romans and Galatians with the **flesh** or **body**, and hence, we can summarise the first element of the Pauline account of sin as follows: the flesh overtakes one's power to perform these actions, which are good by causally affecting the agent to do that which is morally bad. It is significant to note that sin does not affect the agent's epistemic abilities to 'see' the good – at least on an intellectual level. To a certain extent, Aquinas here reads Paul accurately, in that the former interprets humans as able to 'see' good, even if they can bring about the good on all occasions. A significant difference between these accounts, though, lies in that for Aquinas, one's epistemic capacity relates to **conscience**, which is cognitive through and through, and, from a rationalist perspective, if one can cognitively grasp the major premise of a universal syllogism, then one must be able to infer what one **ought** to do in a practical syllogism **and** do it. In contrast, for Paul, whilst conscience might have a cognitive aspect, it does not

sufficiently or necessarily motivate the agent's will to **do** good. Overall, we can summarise Paul's account of sin in the following manner: **sin** refers to the perversion of one's ability to carry out good actions, and hence, sin should be viewed as a dispositional structure that lives **between knowing and doing**.

What causes sin? According to Paul, the main **cause** of sin is the "desires of the flesh" (Romans 6:6-3; 6:12-14). For Paul, the flesh represents that which makes the human sinful in that it inescapably causes the human to act in ways that he knows he should not; however, the flesh is so powerful that even with full-blown epistemic clarity with regards to the good, one may fail to do so. In more general terms, we can argue that Paul regards the appetitive part of humans as the part which has a propensity towards sinful actions, and this is juxtaposed with the intellectual/spiritual part that manages to abstract from appetite. For Paul, Jesus' crucifixion demonstrates the inferiority of the body/flesh, for God allowed (or planned) for this aspect of the Self to suffer death. Thus, viewed symbolically, the event of crucifixion is taken to indicate that there is a value hierarchy between the constitutive parts of humans, i.e., the appetitive part (or the flesh) is inferior whilst the non-material/intellectual/spiritual part is superior – its superiority is proven in that it was never put to death, and, in a stronger claim, it could never have been put to death.

This interpretation is supported by Romans 8:12-14, where Paul suggests that putting to "death the deeds of the body" **through** the Spirit will enable one to **live**. Here, **to live** should be read as referring to mere physical existence. Being alive is not the same as living in line with the spirit and denial of the body. It is a non-disputed possibility that one can simultaneously **live** and be a sinner, completing one's physical existence in this world. Paul seems to suggest that denying the body channels a **different** way of life. Thus, the Christian calling here is that to live differently means to commit to a life in which the Soul constrains the deeds of the body. Likewise, **to live**

should not be interpreted as referring to an idea of an afterlife. This interpretation would seem tempting, especially given Paul's reference to Jesus' resurrection is explicit in Chapter 6. Paul says:

“Do you not know that all of us who have been baptised into Christ Jesus were baptised into his death? We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in newness of life”
(Romans 6:1-4)

“We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to nothing, so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin. For one who has died has been set free from sin. Now if we have died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with him”
(Romans 6:5-9)

One can read the above quotes with the afterlife in mind, i.e., as referring to the promise that the faithful, if they receive grace, will be resurrected in the same manner as Christ did. However, I want to suggest that this would either be an incorrect or an incomplete interpretation of the passage. To **live** in Christ and “with him” refers to the idea that by denying the ‘deeds of the body’, which was proven as inferior by Christ’s crucifixion, one can walk in the newness of life in **this life**. To “be baptised into his death” means to be initiated into the ‘new’ life, which begins by renouncing the ‘flesh’; thus, the ‘newness of life’ does not necessarily suggest a post-death state of affairs but rather a different way of living. The significance of the crucifixion, then, is that it symbolises the non-literal death of the old self, and, at the same time, it marks the beginning of the ‘new’ self in the new way of living. Therefore, the Christian calling is to live **as** a Christian in **this life** by **practising** the new way of life suggested by the event of crucifixion.

Consequent passages in Romans 12 further support the above interpretation. First, Paul reaffirms the inferiority of the flesh by calling Christians to offer their flesh as a ‘sacrifice’ to focus on God. Second, he calls for ‘non-conformity to this world’ and ‘transformation’ through Christ’s resurrection. There are two possible interpretations here. On the one hand, ‘do not conform to this world’ might mean a post-mortem otherworldliness that refers to the afterlife, either as a promise or a reward. While plausible, I think this interpretation is wrong. Paul uses the word “*το αἰῶνι τούτῳ*”, which can refer either to eternal life and hence bring the temporal horizon in line with the previous interpretation about the afterlife, or it can mean *βίος*, i.e., the temporal horizon of *this* existence. I think that Paul calls for this-worldly interpretation of non-conformity to specific ways of life in **this** life. For, why else would he call for a ‘transformation’ of mind? The ‘metamorphosis’/transformation of the mind entails a change in the dispositional structure that affects agency. And moreover, Paul, in the same section, indicates which dispositions a Christian who has effected such a transformation should have – see, for example, Romans 12:9-21 for a suggestive passage that delineates what content the transformation of the mind should have.

As a last note, it is worth noting that Paul, in his mention of Adam as the type of man representing sinfulness, refers to the desires of the flesh as that which leads to sin. However, in Genesis 3, Adam’s sin (and, by extension, Eve’s) is **not** caused by a desire of the flesh but rather by a desire of the mind. It was curiosity rather than the lust of the flesh that caused the original sin, which, according to Paul, is the moment sin enters the world. The punishment reserved in Genesis 3 is due to disobedience, and, to a certain extent, Paul reaffirms that obedience is a virtue through his appeal to Abraham’s obedience to God’s will. However, it is unclear whether Paul regards **curiosity** as a cause of sin or if intellectual pursuits are not sinful themselves.